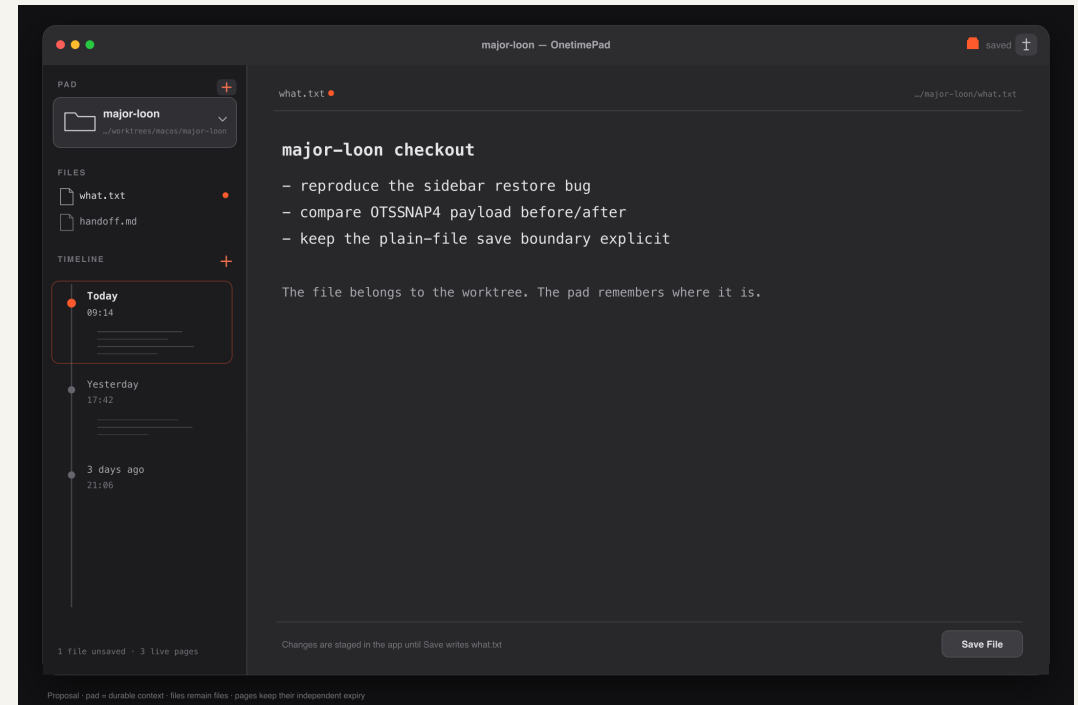


# Multiple Pads for OnetimePad

A folder-scoped context model for git worktrees, plain files, and long days of notes that expire on schedule.

## Recommendation

Make a pad a durable, optionally folder-bound context. Keep one pad active per window and let it scope the existing Files shelf and expiring-page timeline.



# Add context without losing the timeline

The current sidebar makes time legible with very little interaction. Multiple worktrees add a second navigation dimension, but exposing both dimensions as a permanent tree would spend width and attention on inactive work.

## Keep

- Plain files remain ordinary disk artifacts.
- The time rail stays continuous and glanceable.
- Pages keep their independent expiry.
- The app remains a compact utility, not an IDE.

## Add

- A clear identity for each worktree context.
- Fast switching without reopening files.
- Restored selection and scroll position per pad.
- An optional side-by-side window when needed.

## Design rule

Context sits above content. It does not become another content lifetime.

# Use a workspace pattern, scaled down

Successful Mac apps separate durable context from the items edited inside it. The relevant convention is not a new kind of tab; it is a selected place or workspace that scopes navigation beneath it.

## **A** Apple sidebars

Sidebars navigate top-level collections. Apple recommends no more than two hierarchy levels, persistent selection, and a standard way to hide or restore the sidebar.

## **N** Notes and Finder

A durable place remains selected while the content area changes. That persistent selection is the orientation cue a person needs when several worktrees look alike.

## **X** Xcode

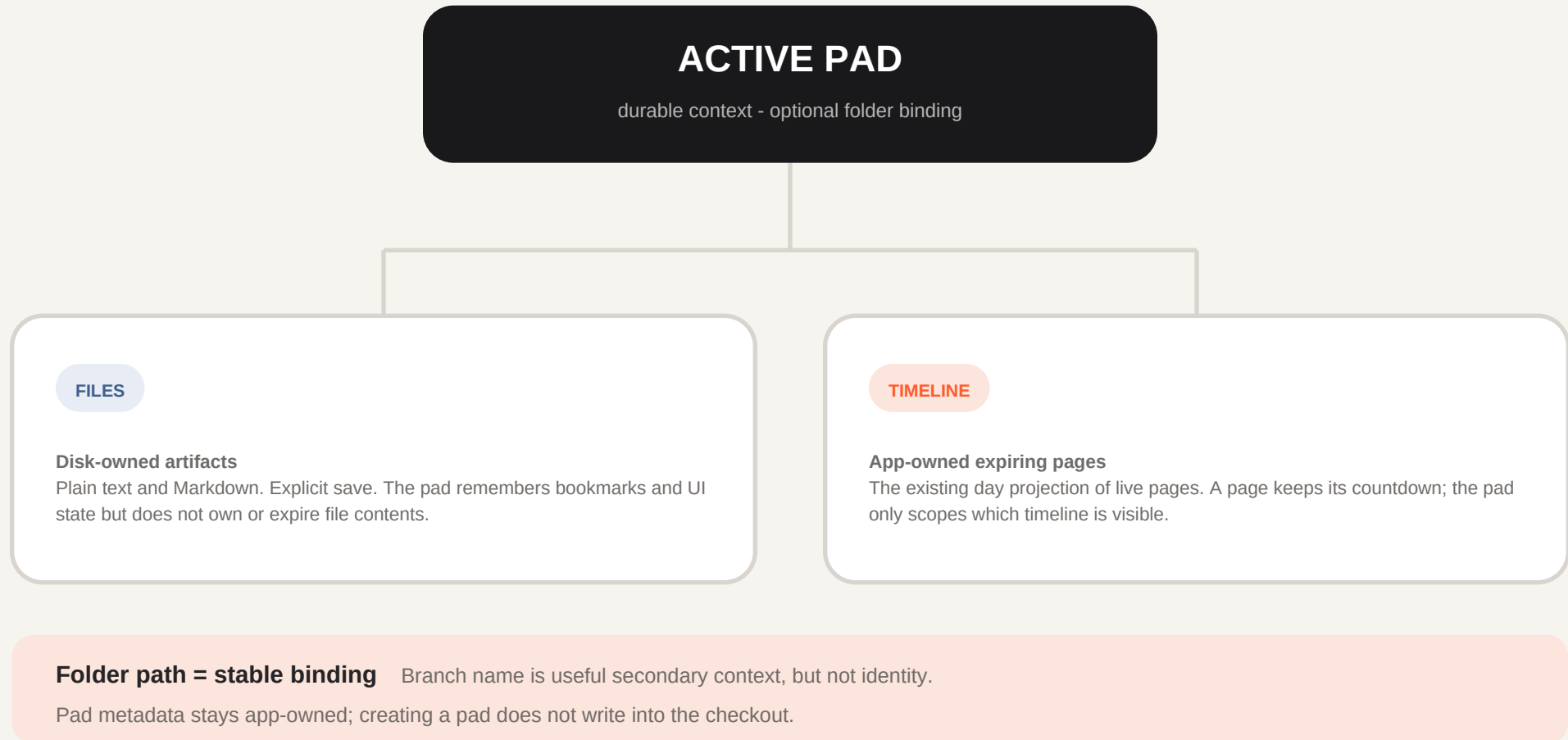
A workspace is the window-level context. Its navigator and editor are subordinate to that workspace, rather than every project becoming another document tab.

## **P** Panic Nova

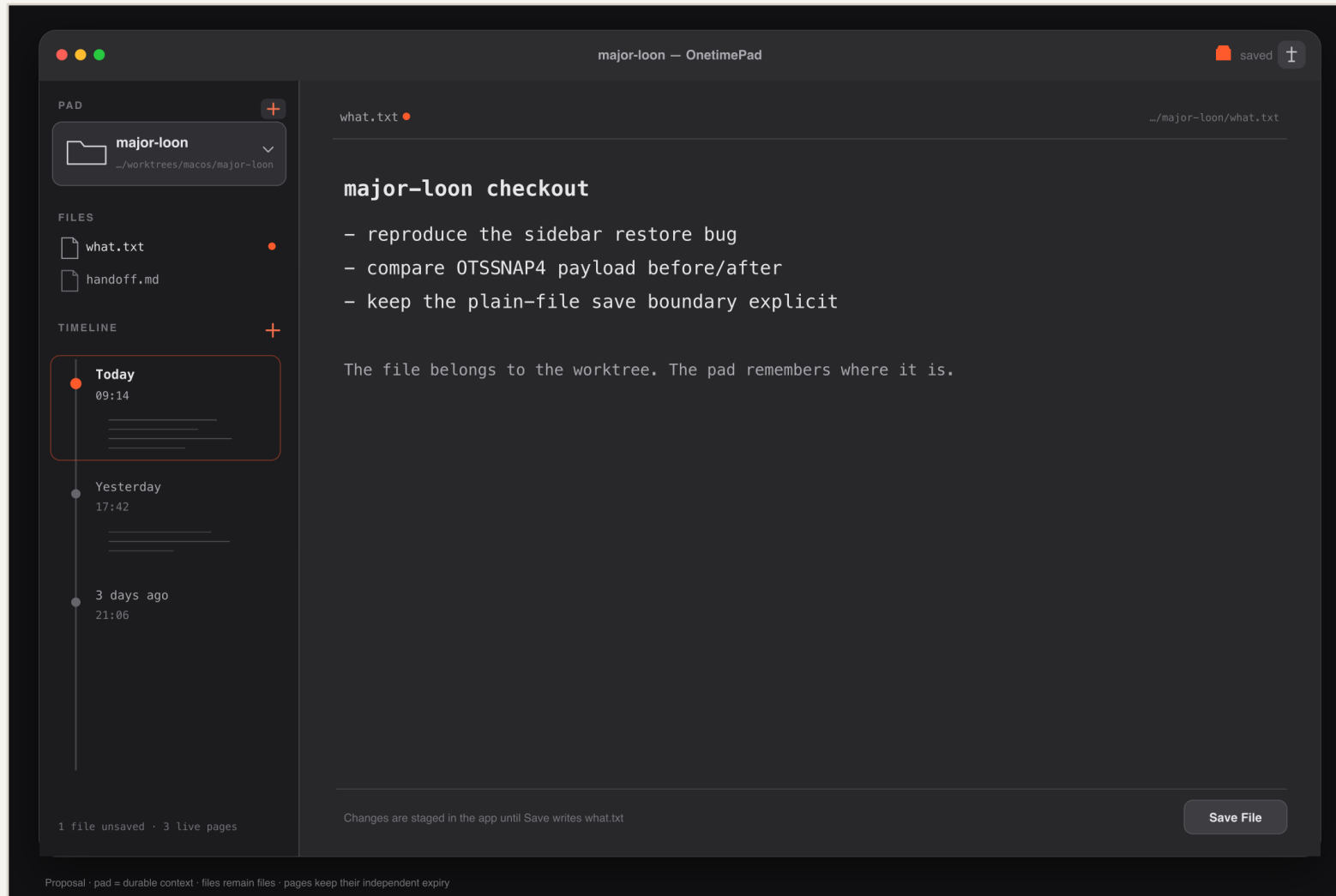
A local project is tied to a folder and opens in a workspace. Additional projects can use windows or tabs according to user preference.

Primary references: Apple HIG - Sidebars, Split views, Windows; Xcode Projects and Workspaces; Panic Nova Quick Tour.

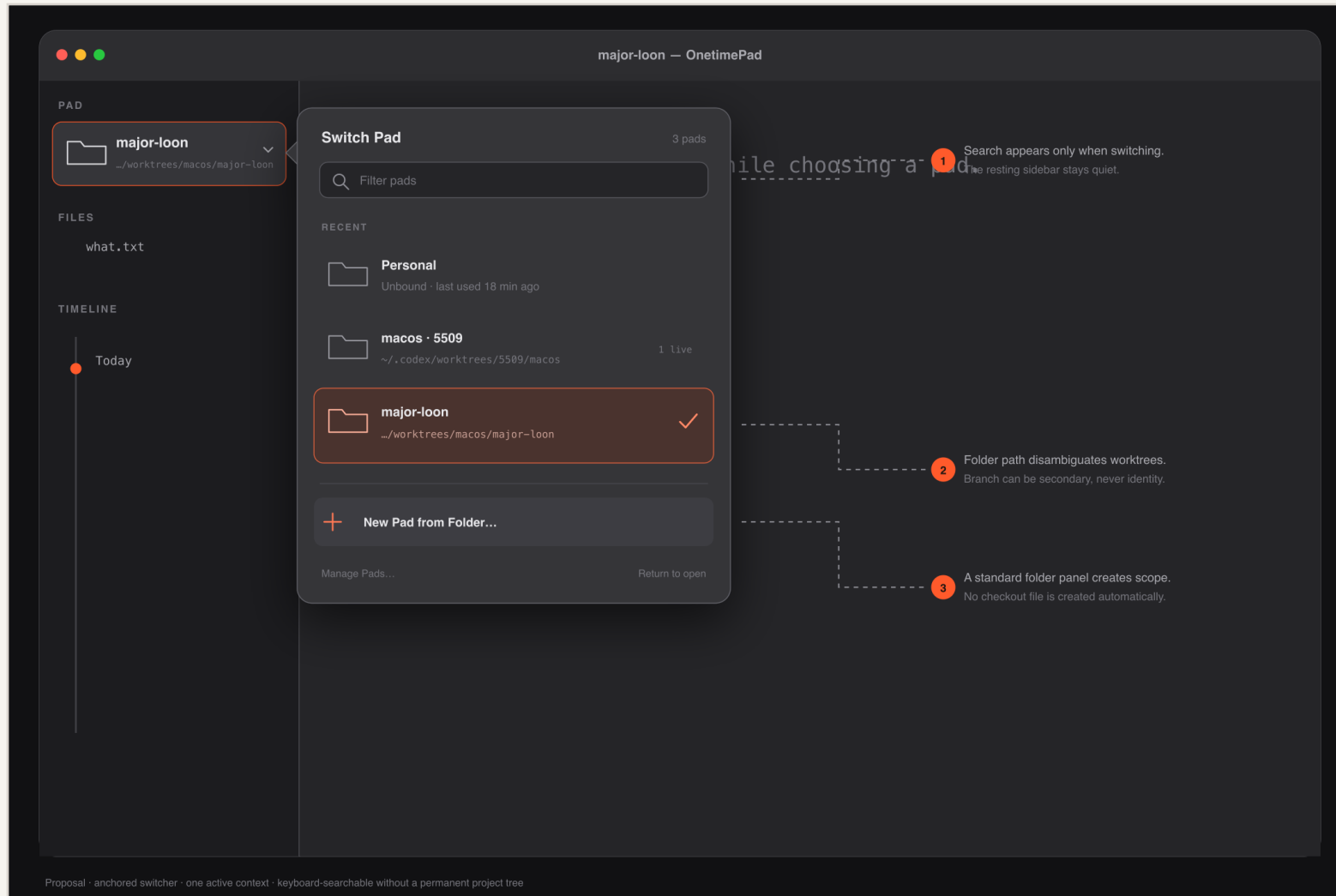
# One active pad scopes two content classes



# The active pad is always named



# Switching is searchable and temporary



# Collapse navigation, never context

### Responsive rule: collapse navigation, never context

The pad name survives in the title bar when the sidebar no longer fits.

WIDE

major-loon — OnetimePad

PAD

major-loon

.../macos/major-loon

FILES

what.txt

TIMELINE

Today

Yesterday

what.txt

checkout notes

- preserve file semantics

- scope the timeline

NARROW

major-loon

saved

what.txt

checkout notes

- preserve file semantics

- scope the timeline

1

Pad identity remains visible.  
The chevron still opens the switcher.

2

Standard toolbar + View menu affordance.  
No hidden edge-only gesture is required.

View · Show Sidebar restores navigation

### Why this matters

A third permanent pane would make the utility feel like an IDE. Collapsing the one sidebar protects the editor, while the persistent title prevents a dangerous context mistake between similar worktrees.

Proposal · wide: context + navigation + editor · narrow: context + editor

# A conservative first dogfood contract

## First release

- Start existing installations with one unbound pad named **Personal**.
- Create a folder-bound pad through **New Pad from Folder....**
- Restore the pad's last selected file or page, editor scroll, and timeline position.
- Route an externally opened file to the single matching pad root; for nested roots, use the most-specific match.
- Keep Command-1 through Command-9 for the existing first-nine-tab shortcuts.
- Never create or modify a checkout file merely because a pad was created.

## Deliberately later

- Open Pad in New Window for side-by-side work.
- Pad groups, favorites, colors, or a full launcher.
- Automatic git branch display and repository metadata.
- A default key binding for Switch Pad; use the project keymap first.
- Cross-device pad identity until local folder bindings and sync semantics are reconciled.

**Routing rule**    one matching root -> that pad | nested roots -> most specific | no match -> active pad

The visible pad selection must update before the file appears, so the context change is never silent.

# What this avoids, and what remains open

|                       |                       |                                                                                  |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Permanent pad list    | REJECT AS DEFAULT     | Consumes the narrow rail and creates a deeper Pads > Days > Entries hierarchy.   |
| Pad tabs beside files | REJECT                | Two meanings of tab in one strip weaken information scent and shortcut behavior. |
| One window per pad    | OFFER, DO NOT DEFAULT | Excellent for side-by-side work, but excessive windows create clutter.           |
| Auto-create what.txt  | REJECT                | Binding a context is not permission to modify a checkout.                        |

## Open product decisions

- 1

What does Remove Pad do while live pages remain?
- 2

Does logical pad identity sync while each folder binding remains local?
- 3

Is 'pad' accepted as both the product's surface and the new user-visible context?

# Project alignment and primary sources

## Accepted ADR-0017

**"Split the object into a durable Tab and an optional, expiring Page."**

The proposed pad groups tabs without becoming another content lifetime.

## Proposed ADR-0028

**"File backed documents are an additional content class, a peer to pages."**

This record is proposed, not accepted. The design preserves its file/page boundary.

## Primary external sources

### Apple Human Interface Guidelines: Sidebars

[developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/sidebars](https://developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/sidebars)

### Apple Human Interface Guidelines: Split views

[developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/split-views](https://developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/split-views)

### Apple Human Interface Guidelines: Windows

[developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/windows](https://developer.apple.com/design/human-interface-guidelines/windows)

### Xcode: Projects and workspaces

[developer.apple.com/documentation/xcode/projects-and-workspaces](https://developer.apple.com/documentation/xcode/projects-and-workspaces)

### Panic Nova: Quick Tour

[help.nova.app/welcome/quick-tour/](https://help.nova.app/welcome/quick-tour/)

### Panic Nova: Workspace settings

[help.nova.app/settings/workspace/](https://help.nova.app/settings/workspace/)

## Repository sources

[docs/adr/0017-durable-tabs-expiring-pages.md](#) (accepted)

[docs/adr/0028-file-backed-documents-are-a-peer-content-class.md](#) (proposed)

[docs/spec/feature/vertical-time-tabs/README.md](#) (draft prototype)